



Honda Clarity FCV

Fuel cell cars

While fuel cell cars are still far from being mainstream, the Auto Expo 2018 saw at least two concepts presented on its show floor – the Toyota FCV Plus and the Honda Clarity Fuel Cell. With the Indian government pushing for electrified mobility, the frequency of alternate fuel vehicles are bound to increase in the country. Mercedes-Benz has previously shown its GLC Fuel Cell SUV option globally, while Tata Motors also has a Starbus Fuel Cell prototype ready for production, which it unveiled back in 2016. These new entrants are not being strictly unveiled in India per se, but both Toyota and Honda brought it to the Auto Expo 2018 as a show of what it is capable of doing with alternate fuel cars.

The Toyota FCV Plus is a four-wheeler concept that may be used for commercial mobility in the ride sharing space. It is also built for autonomous driving, and the interiors are designed to be converted to a living room space if needed. The Honda Clarity Fuel Cell, meanwhile, is a more conventional luxury sedan with quirky design elements, but nothing about it really gives away its alternate fuel powertrain. The Clarity resembles and falls in the Accord Hybrid's category in many ways, and may come to India as an upmarket passenger vehicle once the EV market starts picking up pace in the country.

Mercedes-Benz Concept EQ

The Mercedes-Benz Concept EQ was one of the most impressive and intelligent cars to be present at the Expo, although it was strictly present as just an exhibit. The Concept EQ is a vision of Mercedes-Benz's future mobility plans, coming with Level 5 autonomy, almost every driver assist mechanism thrown in, fully electric powertrain with high density batteries, and a futuristic cockpit with augmented reality displays mounted on the windows and windshield, a retractable steering wheel and swivelling seats that enhance productivity, lifestyle and multitasking. The Concept EQ's presence in India is a sign of intent from Mercedes' part, and will be the platform based on which a number of the company's future cars will be built. Incidentally, India is slowly picking up pace as an important growing market for Mercedes-Benz, and the company continues to hold fort with the highest market share among luxury car makers along with an impressive growth rate. Hopefully, the Concept EQ would feature in India soon enough, as we build our way towards autonomy.



Mercedes-Benz Concept EQ

Hyundai: Ioniq, Kona prototype

Hyundai attracted massive footfall on day two thanks to the presence of its corporate brand ambassador, Shah Rukh Khan. But, the company's portfolio of cars were equally impressive, and Hyundai India had two of its most notable recent cars on display at the Auto Expo 2018 show floor. The Hyundai Ioniq has been the company's go-to car for all purposes autonomous, connected and electric globally, and is in contention for being unveiled in India with its all-electric powertrain. Interestingly, the Ioniq's versatile platform means it is globally available in all formats of powertrains – combustion engine-only, hybrid, and electric. Also present in prototype form is the Kona, although the compact SUV was only present in the all-doors-sealed prototype format. The Kona is also being considered for India, and inside sources tell us that one among the two will be launched in India this year itself with an all-electric powertrain, subject to clearance of permits and paperwork. The Hyundai Ioniq will sit just above the Elantra, while the Kona will slot in between the Creta and the Tucson. Design has always been Hyundai's strength, and the two EVs in store for Hyundai's future India portfolio are in line with the company's design philosophies.